

# Ella's AI Swarm Guide

## Ella’s Linear Workflow Guide ♀

*Your complete field manual for working with the AI team through Linear. Everything you actually need to know, nothing you don't.*

### What Is Linear?

**Linear** is our shared workspace — a smart to-do board where tasks move from idea to published content. Think of it like a kitchen: Michael puts tasks *in*, the AI preps them, you add the secret local-knowledge ingredient, and the AI plates and serves them. You never have to cook the whole meal alone.

### The Pieces of Linear You Actually Use

| Piece    | What It Is                                                 | When You Touch It                           |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Issue    | A single task (e.g., “Record voice memo: Mokulua Islands”) | Every time you work                         |
| Status   | Where the task is in the pipeline                          | When you start or finish                    |
| Comments | The conversation thread on a task                          | When you give feedback                      |
| Assignee | Who the task belongs to                                    | Michael sets this for you                   |
| Cycle    | A 2-week sprint bucket                                     | You just see the label — Michael manages it |
| Project  | A grouping of related tasks (e.g., “Active Oahu Content”)  | Rarely — mostly informational               |

### What You DON’T Need to Worry About

- Creating tasks or projects (Michael does that)
- Setting due dates or priorities (the AI handles scheduling)
- Navigating complex views or filters (just look at “Assigned to Me”)
- Understanding every Linear button or menu

### Your Exact Workflow (6 Steps)

Here's your full loop, every single time you sit down to work:

## Step 1: Open Linear

Open Linear on your phone or computer. The fastest way is to click the link Michael sent you — it'll take you straight to your board. Bookmark it.

## Step 2: Find Your Assigned Tasks

Look at the left sidebar and click **"Assigned to me"** (or "My Issues"). This shows ONLY tasks with your name on them — no noise, no other people's work, no confusion.

You'll see a list of cards. Each card has: - A **title** at the top (what it's about) - A **status tag** (To Do / In Progress / Done / Blocked) - The **project name** or cycle label underneath

## Step 3: Read the Description

Click into a task and read the description. It'll tell you exactly what's needed. Most tasks fall into one of these categories:

- **Voice Memo:** "Record your answers to these questions about [topic]. 5-10 minutes. The AI will extract what it needs."
- **Review:** "Read this draft and check: are the directions correct? Are hours of operation accurate? Does anything feel off to a local?"
- **Follow-Up:** "You mentioned [thing] in your last comment — can you expand on that?"

If the description isn't clear, comment and ask. Michael or the AI will clarify.

## Step 4: Do the Thing

| Task Type  | What You Do                                                                                                    | Time     |
|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Voice Memo | Record yourself talking through the questions. Don't script it — just talk like you're explaining to a friend. | 5-10 min |
| Review     | Read the draft. Check the specific things listed in the task description. Note anything wrong.                 | 5-15 min |
| Follow-Up  | Answer the specific question asked. One or two paragraphs is plenty.                                           | 2-5 min  |

**Important:** You don't need to write articles, format anything, or make things "publish-ready." That's the AI's job. Your job is knowledge and judgment.

## Step 5: Comment the Result

Add a comment on the task with what you did. This is the most important step — if you don't comment, the AI doesn't know to continue. More on how to write great comments in the next section.

## Step 6: Change the Status

After commenting, update the task status:

- If you recorded a voice memo or answered questions → move to **In Review** (or just **Done** if you're sure it's complete)
- If you reviewed a draft and it's good → move to **Done**
- If you reviewed a draft and it needs changes → move to **In Progress** and say what needs fixing in your comment
- If you can't do the task for some reason → move to **Blocked** and explain why

**Pro tip:** Michael set this up so the AI watches for status changes. Moving a card to Done tells the AI to proceed with the next step automatically. You don't need to @mention anyone — the system handles it.

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## How to Comment: The Make-or-Break Skill

Your comments are the steering wheel. The AI reads every comment you write and acts on it. Vague comments = AI guessing = wasted time. Specific comments = AI executing = fast results.

### ☐ GOOD Comments (With Annotated Examples)

#### Example 1: Voice Memo Response

"Just recorded a voice memo — here's the link. Covered all 8 questions about the Mokulua paddle. A few things I emphasized: the put-in is at the boat ramp by the parking lot at the end of Kalaheo Ave (NOT the main beach entrance), paddling out takes 30-45 min depending on wind, and the best time to go is before 9am when the water is glass. Also mentioned that reef-safe sunscreen is state law now — a lot of tourists don't know that."

*Why this works:* It gives the AI context for what's in the audio. The AI can cross-reference these points while transcribing and catch details it might otherwise miss. It also flags the sunscreen law — exactly the kind of local knowledge that makes content authoritative.

#### Example 2: Review With Specific Fixes

"Read through the Lanikai draft. Three things to fix: - Paragraph 2: The directions say 'turn left on Kalaniana'ole' — it's a RIGHT turn coming from Kailua - Parking section: says 'plenty of street parking' — that hasn't been true since 2023. It's almost all residential permit now. Visitors should park at Kailua Beach Park and walk over, or use the limited spots on Mokulua Drive - Hours: says 'open until 8pm' — the beach access closes at sunset, which varies. Just say 'closes at sunset'

Otherwise reads well. The wildlife section is solid."

*Why this works:* Each fix is pinpointed to a specific location in the draft with the correct replacement info. The AI doesn't have to guess what "the parking part feels wrong" means. Bonus: you affirmed what WAS good, which helps the AI preserve those sections.

**Example 3: Follow-Up That Moves Things Forward**

"You asked about rental shops in Kailua. The main ones are Kailua Beach Adventures (on Kalaheo Ave, closest to the boat ramp — they're the biggest operation), Two Good Kayaks (smaller, more personal, on Hamakua Drive), and Kailua Sailboards & Kayaks (they've been around forever, good for windsurfing crossovers). I've used all three. KBA is best for first-timers because they do a solid safety briefing. Two Good Kayaks is better if you want to avoid the crowd. Happy to expand on any of these."

*Why this works:* Instead of just listing names, you gave context and a recommendation — the kind of nuance an AI can't generate from Google. This turns into content that actually helps readers decide.

**❑ BAD Comments (And Why They Stall Everything)**

| Bad Comment                                                      | Why It Fails                                                                                                                    | Better Version                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Just write something about kayaking, you know the usual stuff." | The AI doesn't know what "usual" means to a local. It'll generate generic content that sounds like every other travel blog.     | "For the kayaking piece, focus on the wind patterns — mornings are calm, trade winds pick up by 11am. Also mention that Kailua is inside a protective reef so the water stays flat, unlike North Shore." |
| "This doesn't sound right."                                      | Which part? What should it say? The AI has to guess and will probably guess wrong, creating more back-and-forth.                | "The second paragraph about water temperature says 75°F year-round. It's actually closer to 78-80°F in summer and drops to 74-76°F in winter. Fix that number."                                          |
| "Make it more authentic."                                        | Authentic how? This is the most frustrating feedback for an AI to receive.                                                      | "Add a line about the Kalapawai Market post-beach ritual — locals grab a coffee or sandwich there after morning sessions. That's the real Kailua experience tourists miss."                              |
| "Looks fine." (on something with obvious issues)                 | If you're tired and just approving to clear the queue, quality suffers. Better to flag one thing than rubber-stamp bad content. | "I'm running low on energy today — can I come back to this tomorrow? Want to give it a proper read."                                                                                                     |
| (No comment — just status                                        | The AI gets no signal. It can't tell if you reviewed it,                                                                        | Always add at least one sentence: "Reviewed — directions are accurate,                                                                                                                                   |

change)

skipped it, or the  
status change was  
an accident.

parking info is current.  
Good to publish.”

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## The Golden Rule of Comments

**Write as if you're texting a smart but clueless friend who's never been to Oahu.** They're sharp, they'll execute exactly what you say, but they have zero local context unless you give it to them. Don't assume they know things. Over-explain by one sentence.

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## The 24-Hour Rule (Your Emotional Authority)

You have what we call an **open Emotional Solar Plexus** — which is a fancy way of saying your best decisions come after reflection, not in the heat of the moment. This isn't a weakness; it's a design feature when you work WITH it.

### When to Use the 24-Hour Rule

Any time a task asks you to: - Choose between two or more significant options - Approve a major direction change - Sign off on something that will go live to the public - Make a call that feels high-stakes or uncomfortable

### What to Do

Comment on the task: > “Let me sit with this overnight. I'll have a clear answer for you tomorrow.”

That's it. That comment is 100% acceptable and actually *encouraged*. You are never expected to make a snap decision. The AI and Michael would rather wait 24 hours for the right call than get a rushed answer that creates rework.

### What the 24-Hour Rule Is NOT

- It's not a way to avoid tasks indefinitely. If you need more than a day, say so: “I need until Thursday on this one.”
  - It's not for small, obvious things. If the task is “does this street name look right?” — just answer it.
  - It's not a sign you're slow or indecisive. It's a deliberate workflow designed around how you operate best.
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## Working With AI: The Loop Explained

You might be wondering: “Do I need to talk to the AI directly? Learn a special format? Use some chatbot?”

**No.** You never talk to the AI directly. You just comment on Linear tasks. The AI reads your comments and acts. Here's the full loop:

Michael creates task → AI generates draft or questions

↓

You read the task description

↓

You do the thing (voice memo, review, etc.)

↓

You COMMENT on the task with your result

↓

AI reads your comment → AI takes the next action

↓

AI posts updated version in the comments

↓

You review → comment → loop continues

↓

You mark as Done

## **You Comment → AI Acts**

That's the entire relationship. You never need to: - Send a separate message to an AI - Use a different tool or app - Format anything specially - Worry about triggering the right automation

Just comment. The AI watches. Things progress.

## **If Nothing Happens After You Comment**

Give it a few hours. If nothing happens by the next day: 1. Check that you changed the status (the AI may be waiting on a status signal) 2. Add another comment: "Following up — is this stuck?" 3. If still nothing after another day, ping Michael directly

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## **The Interview Pipeline (Your Main Workflow)**

About 70% of your tasks will follow this pattern. Understanding it deeply means you'll fly through your batches.

### **The Full Pipeline, Step by Step**

#### **PHASE 1: AI GENERATES QUESTIONS**

Michael sets up a task → AI reads the topic and creates 7-8 specific interview questions → task appears in your "Assigned to me" with status "To Do"

#### **PHASE 2: YOU RECORD ANSWERS**

You read the questions → You record a 5-10 minute voice memo → You comment with the audio file and a brief summary → You move status to "In Review"

#### **PHASE 3: AI DRAFTS THE PAGE**

AI transcribes your audio → AI combines your local knowledge with research → AI writes a complete draft → AI posts draft in task comments → Status moves

to "In Review" and shows up in your feed

#### PHASE 4: YOU REVIEW

You read the draft → You check against the task requirements → You note corrections or approve → You comment → Status moves to "In Progress" (if changes needed) or "Done" (if approved)

#### PHASE 5: FINAL PUBLISH (AI handles this)

AI applies your changes → AI does final formatting and SEO → AI marks complete → Content goes into the publishing queue

## Voice Memo Recording Tips

- **Don't script it.** Just talk naturally. The AI is better at extracting from conversational speech than from stiff, rehearsed answers.
- **5-10 minutes** is the sweet spot. If you go to 15 minutes, that's fine. If you hit 20, you might be over-detailing.
- **Stories are gold.** If a question makes you think of a specific experience, tell the story. "One time I was paddling out and..." — that's the content that no other website has.
- **It's okay to skip.** If you don't have a strong answer to a question, just say "I don't have much on that one" and move on. The AI will fill gaps with research.
- **Be conversational.** "Oh, and another thing —" is fine. The AI handles structure.

## Reviewing AI Drafts: Your Checklist

When you open a draft to review, ask yourself:

- ☐ **Are the directions correct?** Left vs. right, street names, landmarks.
  - ☐ **Are the hours/availability accurate?** Open times, seasonal closures, things that changed recently.
  - ☐ **Does the parking/location info match reality?** The AI gets this wrong most often.
  - ☐ **Does anything "feel off"?** Trust your gut. If a description of Kailua Beach doesn't sound like Kailua Beach, flag it even if you can't pinpoint why.
  - ☐ **Are there any legal/rule things to mention?** Reef-safe sunscreen law, beach access rules, no-drone zones.
  - ☐ **Would a local reader say "yep, they actually know what they're talking about"?** This is the ultimate test.
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## Batch Size: 5 Tasks, Always 5

Michael will assign work in batches of exactly **5 tasks**. Never more. Here's why and how to work with this:

### Why 5?

- **5 tasks = ~1 hour of focused work.** You can do it in one sitting without burning out.

- **5 tasks = visible progress.** You finish a batch, you feel accomplished. 30 tasks = you feel like you're drowning.
- **5 tasks = the AI can process in parallel.** While you're on task 2, the AI is already working on your output from task 1.

## How to Work a Batch

1. **Open all 5 tasks.** Skim the titles. Get a sense of what's coming.
2. **Pick the easiest one first.** Build momentum.
3. **One at a time.** Don't context-switch. Complete the full loop (read → do → comment → change status) before opening the next task.
4. **If a task feels hard or draining, skip it.** Come back to it last or flag it for help.
5. **When you finish all 5, you're done.** Don't ask for more. Michael will assign the next batch when it's ready.
6. **If you finish a batch and want more same-day, message Michael.** Sometimes there's a second batch ready. But never feel pressure to ask.

## What If I Can't Finish a Batch?

- **Life happens.** Comment on the remaining tasks: "Got through 3 of 5 — I'll finish the other 2 tomorrow."
- **Don't ghost.** A quick status comment is infinitely better than silence.
- **Don't force it.** If you're tired, foggy, or not in a good headspace, your reviews won't be sharp. Come back fresh.

## Statuses: What Each One Means

Linear uses statuses to track where every task is. Here's exactly what they mean for YOU:

| Status             | Meaning                                                        | When YOU Use It                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Backlog</b>     | Not ready yet. Still being planned.                            | Never — Michael sets this. If you see a task here, don't touch it.                                                                          |
| <b>Todo</b>        | Ready for you to work on. Fresh task.                          | This is where tasks land when Michael assigns them. Start here.                                                                             |
| <b>In Progress</b> | You're working on it right now, or sent it back for revisions. | Move to this when you START working. Move to this when you reviewed a draft and it needs changes from the AI.                               |
| <b>In Review</b>   | You've done your part and the AI is working on the next step.  | Move to this after you submit a voice memo or answer questions. The AI picks it up from here.                                               |
| <b>Done</b>        | Complete. Nothing more needed.                                 | Move to this when you've reviewed a draft and it's good to go. Also use this for voice memos where you're confident no follow-up is needed. |

|                |                                        |                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Blocked</b> | Can't proceed.<br>Needs input or help. | Use this if: you don't understand the task, you need something you don't have, something external is preventing progress. Always add a comment explaining WHY it's blocked. |
|----------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

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## Status Flow Cheat Sheet

Fresh task → Todo

↓

You start working → In Progress

↓

You submit voice memo/answers → In Review (AI works here)

↓

AI returns draft for your review → In Progress (you review here)

↓

You approve → Done

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## When to Escalate to Michael

Most things you can handle in the task comments. But some situations need Michael directly:

### Escalate When:

- **The task description is genuinely confusing** and the AI's clarification doesn't help
- **You've been blocked for more than 2 days** with no movement
- **You discover something that changes the scope** — e.g., "this beach is closed for renovation until October, so this article doesn't make sense right now"
- **You're feeling overwhelmed** and need the batch size reduced
- **A technical issue** prevents you from accessing Linear, recording audio, or uploading files
- **You need time off** — planned or unplanned. A quick heads-up keeps the pipeline adjusted.
- **You have an idea for new content** that's outside your assigned tasks — "we should do a piece on X because Y"

### Don't Escalate When:

- You need clarification on a task → comment on the task itself
- You're running a day behind → just update the task status and keep going
- You're unsure if a review is good enough → trust your gut, submit it, the AI will ask if something's missing
- You want to change the ORDER you do tasks in your batch → that's entirely your call

## How to Escalate

DM Michael with: - **The task ID** (e.g., GRO-142) so he can find it instantly - **One sentence** on what the issue is - **What you need** — clarification, unblocking, reduced workload, etc.

Example: “Hey! GRO-144 is confusing — the description says review a draft but there’s no draft attached. Can you check?”

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## Daily & Weekly Rhythm

### Daily (When You Have a Batch Active)

- **Morning check:** Open Linear for 2 minutes. See if any tasks moved to “In Progress” (meaning the AI returned something for your review).
- **Work session:** When you have energy and time, knock out 2-5 tasks from your current batch.
- **End of session:** Make sure every task you touched has a comment and the correct status.

### Weekly

- **Sync with Michael:** A casual 10-minute check-in. He’ll tell you what’s coming next, celebrate wins, and check how you’re feeling.
- **Batch turnover:** Most batches are designed to be completed within a week. If you finish early, enjoy the gap. If you’re running behind, communicate.

### What NOT to Do

- **Don’t check Linear at night or on weekends.** This isn’t an always-on job. The AI works 24/7; you don’t need to.
  - **Don’t work on tasks that aren’t in your “Assigned to me” view.** If a task doesn’t have your name, it’s not yours.
  - **Don’t worry about “falling behind.”** The batch system prevents pile-ups. If you’re behind, Michael will notice and adjust — you don’t need to stress about it.
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## Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

### Your 6-Step Loop

| Step | Action                                      | Time     |
|------|---------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1    | Open Linear → “Assigned to me”              | 30 sec   |
| 2    | Click into a task, read description         | 1-2 min  |
| 3    | Do the thing (voice memo / review / answer) | 5-15 min |
| 4    | Comment the result (BE SPECIFIC)            | 2-3 min  |
| 5    | Change the status                           | 10 sec   |
| 6    | Move to next task or close for the day      | —        |

### Comment Quality Checklist

- ☐ Did I say WHAT I changed (or WHAT was wrong)?
- ☐ Did I say WHERE in the draft (if reviewing)?
- ☐ Did I give the CORRECT replacement info?

- ☐ Would a smart friend who's never been to Oahu understand what to do?

## Status Decision Tree

Did you just record a voice memo? → In Review  
Did you just review and it's GOOD? → Done  
Did you just review and it needs CHANGES? → In Progress  
Are you actively working on it? → In Progress  
Is something preventing you? → Blocked (+ explain why)

## When to 24-Hour Rule

- Big decisions (approvals, direction changes, go-live signoffs)
- Something feels off but you can't articulate why
- You feel pressure (internal or external) to decide NOW
- Not for: small fixes, factual corrections, clarifications

## When to DM Michael

- Confused after AI clarification attempt
  - Blocked 2+ days with no movement
  - Scope-changing discovery (closures, wrong topic)
  - Feeling overwhelmed
  - Technical issues
  - Need time off
  - Have a content idea
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## You've Got This ☐

Remember: you were brought on because you know Oahu in a way no AI, no database, and no amount of Google searching can replicate. You've paddled those waters. You've felt that trade wind pick up at 11am. You know which parking lots fill up and which beach access points the tourists miss.

The AI handles the words. You provide the truth. That's the partnership.

When in doubt: comment honestly, take your time, and trust your instincts. They're the whole reason you're here.

— The Active Oahu Team